and openly violating their constitutional right to oppose. What is even more alarming is that the institutions that are meant to uphold and protect the democratic structure of the country have also been silenced. The independent media, which is meant to support democracy, has been rendered useless. Instead of holding the current government accountable for their actions, most of the press and media glorifies their empty promises and, ironically, questions the Opposition when they raise the issues of the people and demand transparency from the government.

In the middle of this political scenario, the Indian National Congress, the party that won freedom for the country and is the principal Opposition, was duty-bound to go back among the people of the country and walk with them to rebuild the bridges of hope. The need to protect the Indian philosophy of unity in diversity and diversity in unity was now more urgent than ever. This twin philosophy was the crucial foundation to fight fear with courage, hatred with love, violence with non-violence, divisiveness with unity and lies with the truth.

After many rounds of discussion among the stakeholders, the party finally decided and internally agreed that our intervention would be in the form of a padyatra across the country. This was a moment of immense excitement and anticipation for many people. But for me this decision was even more crucial—it was a moment of great hope and an instant resolve that I had to undertake this journey. Despite the fact that no formal announcement had been made by then, I immediately ensured that the party leadership was informed about my intent to be part of the Yatra.

The planning of the Yatra moved very quickly and positively after this point. The roadmap of the padyatra was drawn out and various committees were formed to undertake preparations. One of the first decisions stipulated by the leadership was that even though the initiative was led by a political party, the Yatra would be an open and inclusive space, where any person or organization who believed in the Indian Constitution could participate. Despite this clarity, there were still many issues that needed to be addressed, such as whether the Yatra would be led by a person or the party as a whole. Would it have a face at all? What would its structure be like?